MS Subbulakshmi was born to a devadasi mother in Madurai. Trained to sing and play instruments from childhood, she began giving small public performances at just nine years old. Subbulakshmi moved to Madras at twenty, both to avoid marriage and to break free of the stigma surrounding devadasis. She proceeded to make a name for herself in Carnatic music, a historically upper-caste- and male-dominated field. Alongside mastering her craft, she also learned compositions from other Indian musical traditions and had a brief stint in film. Her efforts to capture a wider, pan-Indian audience elevated her to the status of a national icon. She was the first musician to receive a Bharat Ratna. She also received the Ramon Magsaysay award for her humanitarian and philanthropic activities.

In 1966, Subbulakshmi was invited to perform at the United Nations in New York. This was just one of several international performances that established her as a cultural ambassador of India.